

ETSY · ONLINE MARKETPLACE

Deploying 50+ times a day without fear

How Etsy made releasing code so routine that any engineer could ship to production in minutes, and how a mid-size team can build the same habit without Etsy's in-house tooling.

50+

deploys to production a day

14,000+

test-suite runs a day

~150

engineers on the shared pipeline

Industry	E-commerce marketplace
Problem	Large, infrequent releases that were risky and slow to recover from
Approach	Small changes, one-click deploys, feature flags, and monitoring everything
Figures as of	Etsy's talk at QCon London, March 2014 [1]

01 The challenge

When every release bundles weeks of changes, each deploy carries weeks of risk. Failures are hard to trace to a single change, rollbacks are painful, and teams respond by releasing even less often, which makes the next release bigger and riskier still.

02 What Etsy did

- **Small changes, shipped continuously.** Engineers pushed small diffs many times a day instead of batching them into large releases.
- **A one-click deploy tool.** Deployinator, Etsy's in-house tool, turned a deploy into a button: build, run the automated tests, update staging, then push live.
- **Feature flags.** New code went to production switched off ("dark"), then was turned on gradually, so deploying and releasing became separate decisions.
- **Pre-commit testing and a staging mirror.** Changes could be tested against the full suite before commit, then checked on a staging environment that mirrored production.
- **Graph everything.** The rule was that anything that can be graphed is graphed, so the effect of every deploy showed up on a dashboard within minutes.

03 The results

By 2014 Etsy was deploying to production more than 50 times a day, with a CI setup serving around 150 engineers and running more than 14,000 test-suite runs daily [1].

The lesson: deploy frequency is a result, not a goal. It follows from making each change small, each deploy boring, and each failure visible and reversible.

04 At your scale: a 90-day plan

You don't need a custom deploy tool. Managed CI and an off-the-shelf flag service give a 5–50 person team the same habit.

Days 1–30 · Baseline	Days 31–60 · Automate	Days 61–90 · Make it routine
• Measure the four DORA metrics as they stand today • Map every manual step between merge and production • Put infrastructure under version control, starting with one environment	• One pipeline in GitHub Actions or GitLab CI: build, test, scan, deploy • One-click (or on-merge) deploys to staging and production • Automated rollback to the previous version	• Feature flags for anything user-facing • A single dashboard showing errors and latency per deploy • Aim to deploy daily; review DORA metrics monthly

05 Readiness checklist

- ☐ Every change goes through a pull request and review
- ☐ Tests run automatically on every push
- ☐ A deploy takes one action, not a runbook
- ☐ Any engineer can deploy, not one gatekeeper
- ☐ Rolling back takes minutes
- ☐ New features can ship switched off
- ☐ You can see errors per deploy within minutes
- ☐ You know your current lead time for changes

Want this plan for your team?

A 30-minute call: we'll baseline where you are and tailor the 90 days.

[Book a discovery call](#)

Sources

1. InfoQ, "How Etsy Deploys More Than 50 Times a Day" (Daniel Schauenberg, QCon London 2014): infoq.com/news/2014/03/etsy-deploy-50-times-a-day
2. Etsy Code as Craft, "Re-Introducing Deployinator": etsy.com/codeascraft

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